

Mahmut Sami Gürdal

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Education

Exp. May 2027	Ph.D. in Human Development Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA
2024	M.S. in Human Development Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA
2022	B.A. in Psychology Özyeğin University, Istanbul, Türkiye

Awards & Honors

2026	Outstanding Graduate Student Award Honorable Mention , Virginia Tech
2024	Outstanding Master's Student , Virginia Tech
2022	High Honors , Özyeğin University
2021	Elected Member , Psi Chi – International Honor Society in Psychology
2020	First Place in Undergraduate Level , 3rd Çiğdem Kağıtçıbaşı Research Festival
2019	First Place in Paper Presentations , 2nd Çiğdem Kağıtçıbaşı Research Festival
2017 – 2022	Full Undergraduate Merit Scholarship (tuition, stipend, and housing) , Özyeğin University

Grants & Fellowships

2026	Graduate Research Grant (US\$ 1,125) Psi Chi – The International Honor Society in Psychology
2026	Short-Term Research Fellowship (CA\$ 12,000) Merit Scholarship Program for Foreign Students (PBEEE) Fonds de recherche du Québec (FRQ) https://doi.org/10.69777/2011343
2025	Travel Grant (US\$ 350) Children and Screens: Institute of Digital Media and Child Development
2022	Academic Fellowship (US\$ 3,000) Hüsnu M. Özyeğin Foundation, Istanbul, Türkiye
2021 – 2022	Undergraduate Research Grant (TRY 4,000) The Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye
2020 – 2021	Undergraduate Research Grant (TRY 3,980) The Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye

Research Experience

- 2024 – Present **Graduate Research Assistant**
Children's Emotions Lab (PI: Dr. Cynthia L. Smith)
Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA
- 2023 – Present **Graduate Research Assistant**
Cognitive Developmental Science Lab (PI: Dr. Koeun Choi)
Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA
- 2026 Summer **Research Intern**
Digital Child Lab (PI: Dr. Caroline Fitzpatrick)
Université de Sherbrooke, Québec, Canada
- 2022 – 2025 **Graduate Research Assistant**
Child Development Center for Learning and Research (PI: Dr. Isabel Bradburn)
Virginia Tech, Blacksburg, VA

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

5. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Özcan, M. Ş., Smith, C. L., & Choi, K. (2026). Effortful control and media use from birth to age 5: A meta-analysis. *Media Psychology*. Advance online publication. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2026.2738788>
4. Walker, A., Quesenberry, E., Morris, K., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Yu, S., Choi, K., Katz, B., & Jeon, M. (2026). False memories: Subjective and objective responses to an “accented” voice assistant. *Phonetica*. Advance online publication. <https://doi.org/10.1515/phon-2025-0080>
3. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Choi, K., Shin, E., & Smith, C. L. (2026). Suppress or reappraise? Differential roles of maternal emotion regulation strategies in mothers' and toddlers' interactive and non-interactive screen media use. *Infant Behavior and Development*, 84, 102203. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.infbeh.2026.102203>
2. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (2026). Self-regulation profiles and social competence in early childhood: A person-centered approach. *Early Education and Development*, 37(2), 371–387. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10409289.2025.2559429>
1. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (2024). Foreign language anxiety and language learning beliefs: A comparative study of six language learner groups. *The Journal of Quality in Education*, 14(23), 44–60. <https://doi.org/10.37870/joqe.v14i23.430>

Manuscripts Under Review and Revision

4. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Çarık, B., Choi, K., Shin, E., & Smith, C. L. (under review). What drives toddler media use? A machine learning investigation of individual, contextual, and media dynamics factors.
3. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Garon-Carrier, G., Madigan, S., & Fitzpatrick, C. (under review). Testing bidirectional associations between preschooler problematic media use and behavior problems.
2. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (in revision). Is reactivity always a risk? High regulation buffers the role of reactivity on preschool learning behaviors.

1. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Smith, C. L., Choi, K., & Bell, M. A. (revised and resubmitted). Childhood temperament and adolescent problematic media use: A longitudinal multi-informant study in the United States.

Manuscripts in Progress

1. Chen, J., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Hong, Y., & Choi, K. (in progress). The interplay between problematic smartphone use, depression, and creative personality in adolescents: A longitudinal cross-lagged model.

Chapters in Progress

1. Choi, K., Chen, J., **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Özcan, M. Ş. (in progress). Infants, infancy, and what we know about what they see.

Reports

1. Bradburn, I., **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Velez, A. (2024). *+Policy Network policy impacts: An assessment of member policy impacts from 2017–2023*. Virginia Tech +Policy Network.

Presentations

Chaired Conference Symposia

1. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Fitzpatrick, C. (submitted). *From early media use to problematic media use: Developmental pathways and outcomes across childhood* [Paper symposium]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.

Peer-Reviewed Oral Presentations

12. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Garon-Carrier, G., Madigan, S., & Fitzpatrick, C. (submitted). *Does problematic media use precede behavior problems? Longitudinal evidence across the preschool years* [Paper presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
11. Chen, J., Özcan, M. S., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Pyon, J., Li, Z., Colbert, M., Hornburg, C., Lee, S. W., & Choi, K. (submitted). *Different perspectives on AI-supported shared reading: Comparing parents and young children* [Paper presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
10. Chen, J., Özcan, M. S., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Pyon, J., Li, Z., Colbert, M., Hornburg, C., Lee, S. W., & Choi, K. (submitted). *The impact of active child participation in AI-supported shared reading on learning* [Paper presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
9. Choi, K., Özcan, M. S., Chen, J., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Wang, Z., Cuevas, K., & Bell, M. A. (submitted). *Toddlers' problematic media use: Longitudinal associations with parental technofence and child executive functioning in infancy* [Paper presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
8. Choi, K., Özcan, M. S., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Chen, J., Colbert, M., Hornburg, C., & Lee, S. W. (2026, June 21–25). *The impact of AI support on preschoolers' learning during parent-child shared e-book reading: Lab-based evidence* [Paper presentation]. The 28th Biennial Meeting of the International Society for the Study of Behavioral Development, Incheon, South Korea.

7. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Smith, C. L., Shin, E., & Choi, K. (2025, November 6–8). *When temperaments align: Toddler temperament as a moderator between parental personality and media use motivations* [Paper presentation]. The 25th Occasional Temperament Conference, College Station, TX, United States.
6. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Smith, C. L., Choi, K., & Bell, M. A. (2025, July 13–16). *From early temperament to later problematic media use: The mediating role of adolescent temperament* [Paper presentation]. The 2025 Digital Media and Developing Minds International Scientific Congress, Washington, DC, United States.
5. Morris, K., Quesenberry, E., Walker, A., Choi, K., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Yu, S., Jeon, M., & Katz, B. (2025, April 10–12). *Shaping interaction: The impact of voice assistant dialects on user experience* [Paper presentation]. The Southeastern Conference on Linguistics (SECOL), Boca Raton, FL, United States.
4. Walker, A., Quesenberry, E., Choi, K., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Jeon, M., Katz, B., Kebede, L., Morris, K., Odom, C., & Yu, S. (2024, April 4–7). *The impact of voice assistant accent on user experience* [Paper presentation]. The Southeastern Conference on Linguistics (SECOL), Athens, GA, United States.
3. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (2021, July 7–10). *Üniversite öğrencilerinin yabancı dil kaygısı ve yabancı dil öğrenimine yönelik inançları arasındaki ilişkinin incelenmesi (En: Examining the relationship between university students' foreign language anxiety and their beliefs about foreign language learning)* [Paper presentation]. The 8th International Eurasian Educational Research Congress, Aksaray, Türkiye.
2. Karakoç, D., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Sezen, N., & Acar, İ. H. (2019, May 3). *Preschool children's coping strategies during self-regulation tasks* [Paper presentation]. The 2nd Annual Çiğdem Kağıtçıbaşı Psychology Research Festival, Istanbul, Türkiye.
1. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Karakoç, D., Sezen, N., & Acar, İ. H. (2019, April 25–27). *Çocukların ve öğretmenlerin çocukların öz düzenlemesi için kullandıkları stratejiler (En: Strategies used by children and teachers for children's self-regulation)* [Paper presentation]. The 14th National Preschool Teaching Student Congress, Istanbul, Türkiye.

Peer-Reviewed Poster Presentations

11. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Çarık, B., Shin, E., Smith, C. L., & Choi, K. (submitted). *Predicting toddler media use: A machine learning approach* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
10. Li, Z., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Özcan, M. S., Chen, J., Pyon, J., Colbert, M., Hornburg, C., Lee, S. W., & Choi, K. (submitted). *Preschoolers' patterning skills in AI-supported versus traditional parent-child shared e-book reading* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2027 Biennial Meeting, Atlanta, GA, United States.
9. Smith, C. L., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Özcan, M. S., Shin, E., & Choi, K. (2026, July 6–9). *Understanding the role of maternal emotion regulation profiles in mother and child screen use* [Poster presentation]. XXV International Congress of Infant Studies 2026, Panama City, Panama.
8. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Özcan, M. S., Chen, J., Colbert, M., Lee, S. W., Hornburg, C., & Choi, K. (2026, April 9–11). *Who reads the story matters: The impact of AI on preschoolers' learning during parent-child shared e-book reading* [Poster presentation]. The Cognitive Development Society 2026 Biennial Meeting, Montreal, QC, Canada.

7. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Smith, C. L. (2025, May 1–3). *Longitudinal investigation of self-regulation related to changes in internalizing and externalizing behaviors across early childhood* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2025 Biennial Meeting, Minneapolis, MN, United States.
6. Smith, C. L., Özcan, M. S., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Shin, E., & Choi, K. (2025, May 1–3). *Children's regulation starts with the parents: A latent profile analysis of parent emotion regulation strategies* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2025 Biennial Meeting, Minneapolis, MN, United States.
5. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Choi, K., Shin, E., & Smith, C. L. (2024, March 21–23). *Understanding parental factors associated with toddlers' video viewing: A chained mediation model investigating the roles of parental emotion regulation, media use, stress, and media use motive* [Poster presentation]. The Cognitive Development Society 2024 Biennial Meeting, Pasadena, CA, United States.
4. **Gürdal, M. S.**, Choi, K., Shin, E., Kim, J., Yu, S., & Smith, C. L. (2023, March 23–25). *Associations of maternal emotion regulation and mothers' and toddlers' screen use* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2023 Biennial Meeting, Salt Lake City, UT, United States.
3. **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (2022, June 19–23). *Associations among foreign language anxiety, self-regulation, and beliefs toward foreign language learning* [Poster presentation]. The 26th Biennial Meeting of the International Society for the Study of Behavioral Development, Rhodes, Greece.
2. Aktay, T., Kızıldaş, E., **Gürdal, M. S.**, Akkan, A., & Acar, İ. H. (2021, April 7–9). *The contributions of teacher-child relationships to children's social competence* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development 2021 Virtual Biennial Meeting, Virtual.
1. Akkan, A., Aktay, T., Kızıldaş, E., **Gürdal, M. S.**, & Acar, İ. H. (2020, June 29). *Exploring Turkish and American children's reactions to a disappointing situation* [Poster presentation]. The 3rd Annual Çiğdem Kağıtçıbaşı Psychology Research Festival, Istanbul, Türkiye.

Invited Presentations

6. **Gürdal, M. S.**, et al. (2026, October 1). *Digital wellness for kids* [Invited group presentation]. Hokie Wellness, Blacksburg, VA.
5. **Gürdal, M. S.** (2025, November 14). *Role of child temperament and maternal personality on maternal media use motivations*. Hokie Highlights, Blacksburg, VA.
4. **Gürdal, M. S.** (2025, April 11). *Early predictors of behavioral and media use outcomes: A longitudinal perspective*. Hokie Highlights, Blacksburg, VA.
3. **Gürdal, M. S.** (2024, December 5). *Graduate talks*. Psi-Chi: The International Honor Society in Psychology (Özyeğin University Chapter), Virtual.
2. **Gürdal, M. S.** (2024, February 16). *How do maternal factors affect toddlers' video viewing?* HDFS Brown Bag Series, Blacksburg, VA.
1. **Gürdal, M. S.** (2023, July 26). *Pathways in psychology: A conversation with prospective college students*. Özyeğin University, Virtual.

Teaching Experience

Statistical Methods Lab Instructor

Spring 2027 HD 5714: Regression, Virginia Tech (Scheduled)
Fall 2026 HD 5514: Research Methods, Virginia Tech

Instructor of Record

Spring 2026 HD 1004: Childhood and Adolescence, Virginia Tech ($N = 37$; *Rating: 5.50/6.00*)

Teaching Assistant

Fall 2025 HD 1004: Childhood and Adolescence, Virginia Tech
Spring 2024 HD 3254: Curriculum in Early Childhood, Virginia Tech
Fall 2023 HD 3214: Infancy and Early Childhood, Virginia Tech
Spring 2023 HD 3254: Curriculum in Early Childhood, Virginia Tech
Fall 2022 HD 3214: Infancy and Early Childhood, Virginia Tech

Guest Lectures

Fall 2025

- Childhood and Adolescence (HD 1004), Virginia Tech
Topic: Schooling and Choosing an Occupation in Adolescence
- Childhood and Adolescence (HD 1004), Virginia Tech
Topic: Self-Regulation in Early Childhood

Spring 2025

- Special Issue: Developmental Cognitive Neuroscience (PSYC 4093), Virginia Tech
Topic: Real-World Applications of Attention Research

Mentoring & Supervision

2025 – Present **Research Mentor**, Children's Emotions Lab
- Training and supervising 8 URAs in behavioral temperament coding

2024 – Present **Research Mentor**, Cognitive Developmental Science Lab
- Training and supervising 10+ URAs in experimental data collection

Professional Service

Ad Hoc Reviewer

- Early Education and Development
- Computer Assisted Language Learning (Student reviewer)

Conference Reviewing

- Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD), 2027 Biennial Meeting (Student Reviewer)
- Interaction Design and Children 25th Conference (Proceeding paper)

Departmental & University Services

2025 – 2026 **Senator**, Virginia Tech Graduate and Professional Student Senate
2025 – 2026 **Board Member**, Virginia Tech HDFS Graduate Student Association
2024 **Reviewer**, Virginia Tech Graduate Student Travel Fund Program

Outreach & Community Engagement

- November 2025 **AI and Robots for Young Children's Learning [Hands-on Booth]**
Virginia Tech Science Festival, Blacksburg, VA
Role: Organizer
- May 2025 **Let's Take Turns in Playful Reading with AI Voices! [Hands-on Booth]**
Virginia Tech ICAT Day, Blacksburg, VA
Role: Organizer
- February 2024 **Conversational AI Agents for Children's Learning [Hands-on Booth]**
Belview Elementary School STEM Family Night, Radford, VA
Role: Organizer

Professional Memberships

- 2024 – Present Cognitive Development Society (CDS)
- 2022 – Present Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD)
- 2021 – Present Psi Chi – The International Honor Society in Psychology

Computer Skills

- Statistical Analysis: SPSS, R, LISREL, HLM, *Mplus*, Jamovi
- Data Collection: PsychoPy, E-Prime, Qualtrics, QuestionPro
- Document Preparation: $\text{\LaTeX}$, Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint)